

France: Le Pen's Bardella rift may dent her credibility

送信者: EG Europe 受信日時: 2026-09-15 00:29

【メール原文】

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Le Pen's rift with Bardella threatens to undermine her credibility

14 Sep 2026 11:27 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Marine Le Pen still dominates opinion polls for both the first and second rounds of the presidential election on 18 April and 2 May, but a rift with her de facto number two, Jordan Bardella, has drawn attention to her contradictory economic policies.

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The recent election victory of the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) in Saxony-Anhalt is a double-edged sword for Le Pen: Though it confirms a rising tide of nationalist populism in Europe, the party's soft-pedaling of Germany's Nazi past may push older French voters toward more mainstream candidates.

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Eurasia Group continues to assign a 35% probability to a Le Pen victory and 40% odds to the strongest establishment candidate, the former centrist prime minister Edouard Philippe.

Le Pen's run of good fortune has suffered a self-inflicted setback. The far-right leader has quarreled with her popular number two, Bardella, who had been pushing the National Rally (RN) toward more broadly acceptable positions on several key issues. After Le Pen's election ban was lifted on appeal on 7 July, she removed Bardella as the party's candidate. She had previously said that he would be the candidate unless her embezzlement conviction and jail sentence were also overturned. Both were confirmed by the Paris appeal court, but she quickly reversed course and decided to run herself before consulting him.

Le Pen is now hardening positions that already looked inconsistent. Key RN economic advisers encouraged Bardella to make an independent presidential run. He declined, but Le Pen fired economic adviser Francois Durvy for encouraging the independent run, and relations with Bardella have since suffered. In recent days, moves by Bardella to shift RN policy toward the middle ground have been publicly reversed. Reports that Le Pen's once-estranged niece, Marion Marechal-Le Pen, may play a greater role in the campaign also suggest a weakening of Bardella's attempt to make key elements of the RN's platform more acceptable to mainstream voters.

Instead, Le Pen is doubling down on her so-called neither right nor left economic policies, an incompatible mix of low taxes and high social spending. RN officials close to Le Pen have also advocated

hard-line positions on other issues where Bardella had advised caution. They have revived the party's demand for a complete ban on the Muslim headscarf, which would violate the constitution. They have also suggested that a future RN government would "turn off the tap" of French military and economic aid to Ukraine—reviving memories of Le Pen's past links to Vladimir Putin.

Party officials deny the existence of a Le Pen-Bardella rift. Bardella said last week that he "backed Marine 2,000%." He appeared with her at a campaign rally in her constituency in northern France on Sunday, but senior RN sources confirm to Eurasia Group that relations between the two, once touted as unshakeable, have fallen to their lowest ebb.

An outright split is unlikely, but the tensions may still damage Le Pen's presidential prospects. The quarrel reinforces two long-standing criticisms: that the RN is a family business and that it lacks the intellectual discipline to govern. Most importantly, Bardella's sidelining draws attention to Le Pen's Achilles heel—her muddled economic policies. Opinion polls and surveys by both Ipsos and Elabe find that Bardella performs better than Le Pen among center-right, older, and more economically conservative voters. Those groups define the RN's ceiling.

The AfD's victory in Saxony-Anhalt is, counter-intuitively, another possible headwind. On the surface, the triumph of the populist-nationalist AfD party in the German state of Saxony-Anhalt offers some encouragement to Le Pen, suggesting that the anti-establishment tide is running high in Europe. In practice, however, the outcome may hurt her. Significantly, Le Pen has said nothing publicly about the AfD's victory. Instead, one of her closest allies, Jean-Philippe Tanguy, deputy for the Somme, said that he was "horrified" by the success of a party that "minimizes" Germany's Nazi past. Le Pen is uncertain whether the AfD's sweeping victory is good or bad news for her. Le Pen fears that the success of a Nazi-nostalgic party in Germany will ring alarm bells among undecided, older French voters and push them toward the mainstream.

Meanwhile, Edouard Philippe is trying to accelerate his own campaign. Polls in the last week show him still in the range of 17% to 20% in the first round, ahead of other centrist and left-wing candidates, but 13 to 15 points behind Le Pen. One poll, by Cluster17, showed him neck-and-neck with the hard-left candidate Jean-Luc Melenchon at 18%. Philippe had originally counted on other centrist and center-right candidates withdrawing by January or February to clear the field for him. This week, he invited five center and center-right parties to hold talks in late October to prevent an "all extremes" second round. Philippe's approach was rebuffed by the leaders of the other parties, as he knew it would be. Nonetheless, he hopes that his appeal will persuade other senior politicians and undecided centrist voters to move into his camp before year-end.

Happy to discuss,

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